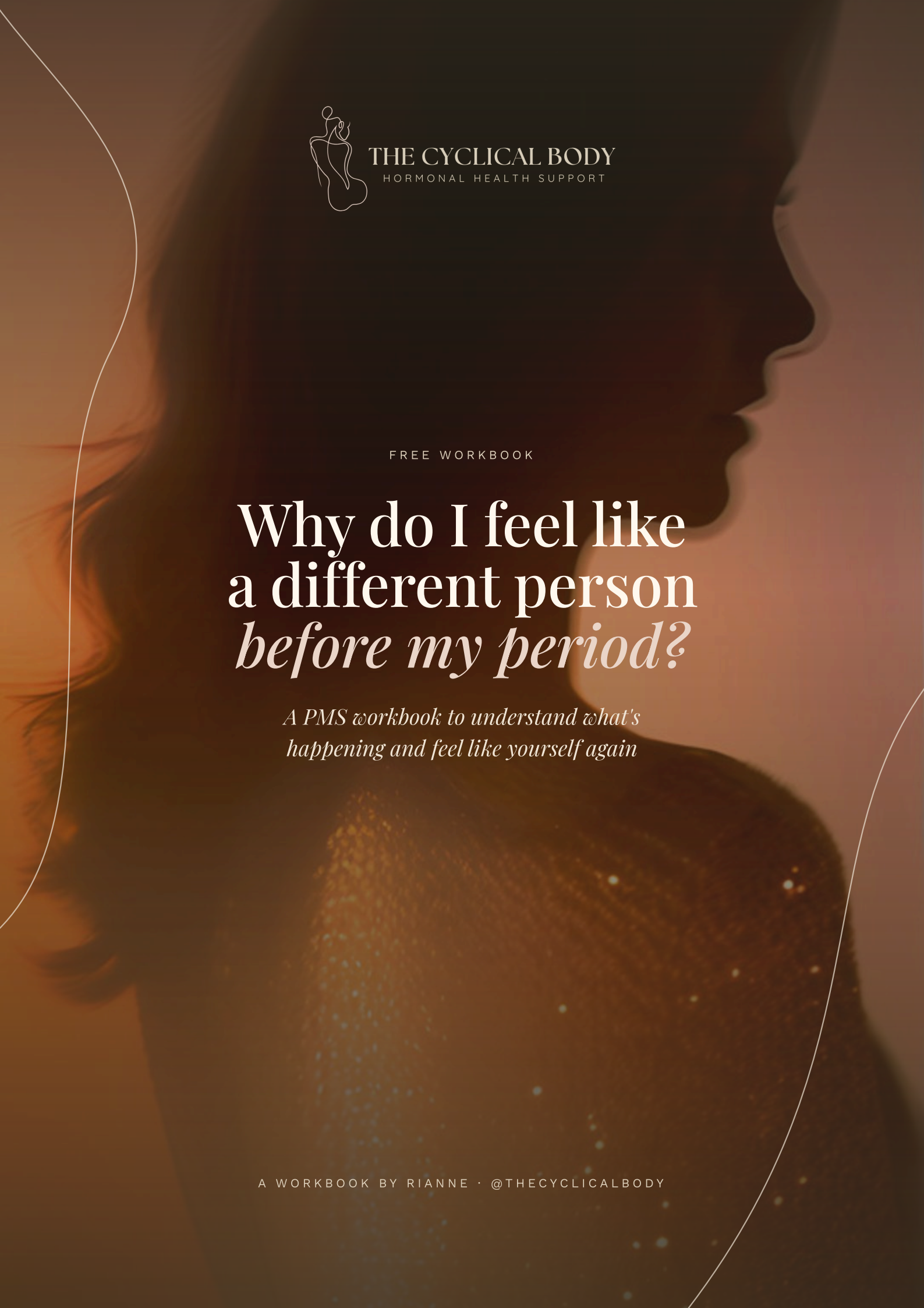


THE CYCLICAL BODY
HORMONAL HEALTH SUPPORT

FREE WORKBOOK

Why do I feel like a different person *before my period?*

A PMS workbook to understand what's happening and feel like yourself again

A WORKBOOK BY RIANNE · @THECYCLICALBODY



BEFORE WE START

Why is everybody so annoying *all of a sudden?*

It's a few days before your period. Someone next to you is chewing on something. Just chewing, like a normal person, and somehow it's the most annoying sound you've ever heard.

You cry at an advert for an animal charity, eat all of the cookies and want chips afterwards, lie awake at 3am wondering why everyone is so stupid, and get annoyed at your colleague for asking "how's it going?"

Maybe you've thought you just have a short fuse. Some weeks you're calm and on top of everything, and other weeks the smallest thing sets you off, followed by not being able to stop eating, whilst you're angry at yourself for eating so much.

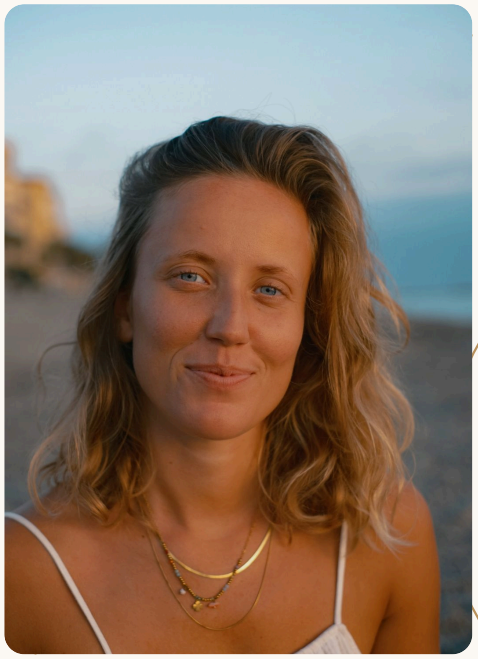
Then your period starts. Within a few days it's like a veil has lifted, and you feel like yourself again. You don't even notice the chewing anymore.

It's easy to miss that it's the same week every month. **Once you see the pattern, everything makes more sense, and you can start doing something about it.**

BEFORE WE START

Hi, *I'm Rianne*

For years I thought my mood swings, extreme cramps and an exhaustion that sleep never fixed were just who I was.



I believed that if I found the right protocol, the right supplement or the right routine, everything would click into place. Instead, I burned out completely, and understood I was running in a system that was never built for my body.

After years of being dismissed, I wanted real answers, for myself and for other women. So I went back to studying.

It took some time and a lot of hormone research, but now my body brings a stability I never thought was possible. No more PMS and cramps, no more random energy leaks or brain fog. That would have sounded crazy to me before.

In this workbook I share what I wish I'd known ten years ago, without the fear, the drama or the 47-step morning routine nobody follows. I really hope it can help you too. And always feel free to reach out to me, I'm here for you!

x Rianne

BEFORE WE START

You're far *from alone*

9 in 10

Up to 9 in 10 women notice at least one change in the days before their period. For between 1 in 5 and 1 in 3 women, these changes are strong enough to affect daily life.

What this workbook gives you

You'll find practical to-dos for each type of symptom, space to reflect, and a simple tracker to see what changes over two cycles.

Understand

What happens in your body before your period.

Recognise

Which symptoms play a role for you.

Try

Two to-dos to start with, tracked over two cycles.

Who this workbook is for

This workbook is written for natural cycles. If you use a hormone-free method, such as a copper IUD, condoms or cycle tracking, everything in it applies to you. If you use the pill, patch, ring, implant or injection, you don't have a natural cycle in the same way, so some parts may not fit.

How to use this workbook

Print it if you can, so you can tick, write and track by hand. Reading on your phone? Keep a notebook or a note on your phone next to you and write your answers there. For the tracker, one line per day is enough: the day of your cycle and a score from 0 to 3 for each area.

This workbook is for information and self-reflection. It doesn't give a diagnosis and it doesn't replace medical advice.

THE CYCLICAL BODY
HORMONAL HEALTH SUPPORT

PART 1

What's happening *in your body*

PMS is not a sign that something is wrong with your hormones. To understand why, it helps to look at what happens in the second half of your cycle.

WHAT'S HAPPENING IN YOUR BODY

The second half of *your cycle*

1 **Progesterone rises after ovulation.**

When you ovulate, the follicle that released the egg turns into a small, temporary gland called the corpus luteum. This gland makes progesterone, and a lot of it: **in the second half of your cycle, progesterone rises to around 25 times its level in the first half**, and peaks about a week after ovulation. Its main job is to prepare the lining of your womb for a possible pregnancy. It also raises your body temperature slightly, which is one reason sleep can feel different in these days.

2 **Your brain turns some of this progesterone into a calming substance.**

Your brain cells talk to each other with chemical messengers. One of them, GABA, works like a brake: it slows things down, so you can settle, switch off and fall asleep. **The substance your brain makes from progesterone makes your brain more sensitive to GABA.** For most people, this gives a mild sense of calm or sleepiness in the second half of the cycle.

3 **Your hormones fall in the days before your period.**

The corpus luteum only keeps working if an egg has been fertilised. If you're not pregnant, it starts to break down after about ten to fourteen days. As it does, both progesterone and oestrogen fall quickly over the last days of your cycle. **That drop is the signal for your womb to shed its lining, which is your period.** It also means the calming effect from point 2 fades, and the brain has to adjust to a quick change in hormones within just a few days.



When your hormones *fall*

4 Some brains react more strongly to that drop.

Research suggests that people with PMS don't have different hormone levels. What differs is how their brain responds to the rise and fall. You can compare it to coffee: two people can drink the same cup, and one feels fine while the other feels jittery. In the same way, the same hormone changes can pass almost unnoticed in one person, while another person's brain reacts with irritability, low mood or tension. Research suggests this difference shows up in the brain systems that regulate mood, such as the serotonin system, and that it may be partly inherited.

5 That reaction can show up in many ways.

Your hormones don't only act on your womb. They work throughout your brain and body, which is why PMS rarely shows up as just one symptom. You may notice changes in your mood, such as irritability, low mood, tension or mood swings. In your body, you may feel bloated or have tender breasts, headaches or aches. Your appetite can change, with cravings or feeling hungrier than usual. Your sleep can be lighter, or you may need much more of it. And your energy can dip, with tiredness or trouble concentrating. Most people have a mix of a few of these, and that mix can differ from cycle to cycle.

6 Your hormones are usually normal.

In PMS, hormone levels are usually within the normal range. That's why **a hormone test on its own doesn't show whether you have PMS**, and why most of what helps focuses on how your body and brain respond.

Sometimes something *else is going on*

Symptoms that look like PMS can also come from, or be made worse by, something else.

Think of thyroid problems, low iron, or low mood or anxiety that is there most of the month and gets worse before your period. Conditions such as PMOS (previously PCOS) or endometriosis, and the hormonal changes of perimenopause, can also play a role.

If your symptoms are there for most of the month, are getting worse over time, or don't improve after a few cycles of the to-dos, **it's worth looking into this further**, including blood tests where they fit.

> *The good news is that there is a lot you can do to ease how your body and brain respond.*

The next pages help you find out where to start.

THE CYCLICAL BODY
HORMONAL HEALTH SUPPORT

PART 2

Do you *recognise this?*

PMS can show up in many different ways, and no two people have exactly the same mix.

DO YOU RECOGNISE THIS?

Tick what *you notice*

Tick the symptoms you notice in the days before your period.

Body

- ◯ Breast tenderness or swelling
- ◯ Bloating or feeling swollen
- ◯ Headaches
- ◯ Muscle or joint aches

Appetite

- ◯ Cravings
- ◯ Eating more than usual

Sleep

- ◯ Sleeping badly
- ◯ Needing much more sleep

Mood

- ◯ Irritability or anger
- ◯ Low mood or sadness
- ◯ Anxiety or tension
- ◯ Mood swings
- ◯ Feeling overwhelmed

Energy

- ◯ Tiredness or low energy
- ◯ Trouble concentrating
- ◯ Less interest in things you usually enjoy

DO YOU RECOGNISE THIS?

A quick check *for PMDD*

For a smaller group of people, premenstrual symptoms are severe enough to seriously affect daily life. This is called PMDD (premenstrual dysphoric disorder), and it responds well to treatment.

2 to 5% PMDD affects around 2 to 5 in every 100 women.

- ◯ I ticked five or more symptoms on the previous page.
- ◯ In those days, at least one of these is much stronger than usual for me: feeling hopeless or very down on myself; feeling very anxious, tense or on edge; sudden mood swings, such as bursting into tears or feeling easily hurt; strong irritability or anger, or many more arguments than usual.
- ◯ My symptoms seriously get in the way of my work, relationships or daily life.

If you ticked all three, it's worth talking to your doctor about PMDD. Take this workbook with you, so you can show what you notice and when. The to-dos in this workbook can help alongside that.

If you're having a very hard time

If you have thoughts of harming yourself or of not wanting to be here, please don't wait for your period to pass. Contact your doctor or a crisis line today. You deserve support right now.

THE CYCLICAL BODY
HORMONAL HEALTH SUPPORT

PART 3

What *you can do*

PMS can feel like something that simply happens to you, but there is a lot you can do to make these days easier.

What helps is often *small and practical*

The changes that help are often small and practical: what you eat, how you move, how you sleep and how you plan your week. Many of them work best when you keep them up across your whole cycle, not only in the days before your period.

How your thoughts shape what you feel

Your brain doesn't only register what happens in your body; it also interprets it. When you expect something to feel bad, or see it as a sign that something is wrong, your brain can turn up the volume on the signals coming from your body. This is well known from pain research: worrying about pain, or expecting it to be bad, goes together with feeling it more strongly. It works the other way too. **When you understand what is happening and know it will pass, the same signals often feel less threatening.**

This also seems to apply to PMS. In a well-known experiment, women who were told they were in the days before their period reported more bloating and pain than women who were told their period was still far away, regardless of where they actually were in their cycle.

> *This doesn't mean your symptoms are imagined, or that you can simply think them away. What you feel is real.*

It means that the way you look at your symptoms is one of the things you can influence, alongside what you eat, how you move and how you sleep.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Your turn: *reflect*

What do you usually think or say to yourself when you notice your first premenstrual symptoms?

What did you learn about periods (and PMS) growing up, and how does that still shape how you see these days?

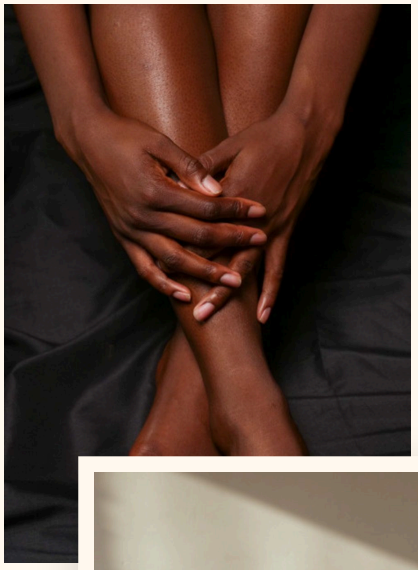
If a close friend described your symptoms to you, what would you say to her?

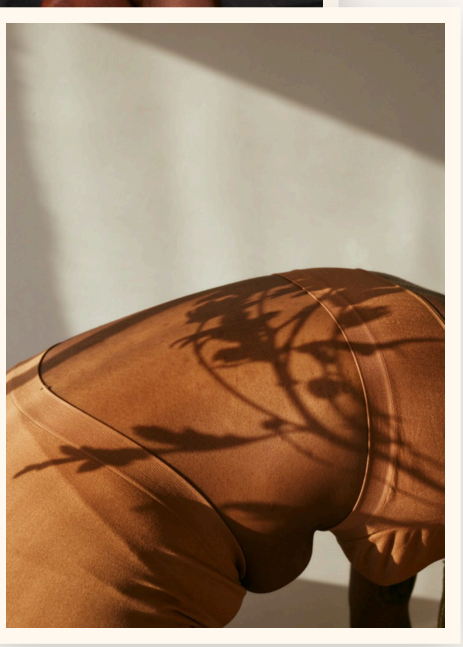
How to use the next pages

On the next pages you'll find to-dos for each area. You don't need to do them all. Start with the area where you ticked the most on the checklist, pick two to-dos that feel doable for this cycle, and add more later if you like.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Your *body*





Breast tenderness, bloating, headaches and aches often follow the same pattern each cycle. The rise and fall of progesterone and oestrogen affects how much fluid your body holds on to and how sensitive your breast tissue is, which is why these symptoms tend to come and go with your cycle.

Two things stand out in the research. The first is calcium. In the largest study on this, women who took calcium every day for three months had noticeably fewer premenstrual symptoms than women who took a dummy pill, with less bloating and fewer aches, but also fewer cravings and less low mood.

Researchers don't yet know exactly why calcium helps, but it plays a key role in how your nerves and muscles work. You don't need a supplement to get enough: **calcium-rich food with each meal goes a long way.**

48%

After three months of daily calcium, premenstrual symptoms dropped by almost half (48%), compared with about a third (30%) in women who took a dummy pill.

The second is movement. Regular exercise can reduce premenstrual symptoms overall, including physical ones. You'll read more about this under "Your energy".

YOUR BODY

Try this *cycle*

TO-DOS

- [ ] Have a calcium-rich food with each meal, such as yoghurt, cheese, fortified plant milk, tofu made with calcium, or tinned sardines. You'll find more ideas and tips in the appendix.
- [ ] Keep moving on the days your body feels heavy. Gentle movement counts, such as a walk outside, an easy bike ride, a swim, a yoga or stretching session, or dancing to a few songs in your living room.
- [ ] Note which physical symptoms come back each cycle, and on which days, in the tracker in part 4.

REFLECT

Which physical symptom bothers you most, and when does it usually start?

How do these physical symptoms affect what you do, or how you feel about yourself, in those days?

What has helped your body feel better before, even a little?

Headaches and migraine

Headaches and migraine that come back around your period are often linked to hormonal shifts, and there is usually more you can do about them than you might think. If they affect you, I'd be happy to look at this with you in a 1:1 conversation.

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Your *appetite*

Your body uses slightly more energy in the days before your period, so it's normal to feel hungrier. Research that brought together many studies found that women eat a little more in the second half of their cycle, and the energy your body uses at rest goes up slightly too. **Part of the extra hunger is simply your body asking for a little more fuel.**

+170	About 170 extra calories a day in the second half of your cycle. That's roughly one slice of bread with cheese.

Cravings are not a lack of willpower. They can feel stronger when you go too long without eating, and in the calcium study on "Your body", cravings were among the symptoms that improved. Regular, filling meals help you meet that small extra need before it turns into strong cravings later in the day.

Alcohol is worth a mention too. Research has found that women who drink more alcohol report PMS more often. It isn't clear which comes first, but keeping alcohol low in these days is an easy step to try.



YOUR APPETITE

Try this *cycle*

TO-DOS

- [ ] Eat regular meals with protein, fibre and some fat, so you don't run on empty. See "How to build a plate" in the appendix.
- [ ] Allow yourself to eat a little more in these days, for example a healthy snack.
- [ ] Keep alcohol low in the days before your period.

REFLECT

When do your cravings usually start, and what is happening at that moment?

How do you usually feel after giving in to a craving, and what do you say to yourself then?

What does a filling meal or snack look like for you, and when could you plan it into your day?

Your *mood*

Irritability, low mood and tension can feel overwhelming when they seem to come out of nowhere. There is a biological reason they show up at this point in your cycle.

Brain scans suggest that in people who are sensitive to the hormone drop before a period, the serotonin system responds differently in these days. Serotonin is one of the messengers that helps keep your mood steady, so when its signal is weaker, **your emotional buffer gets thinner**. Small things can then feel bigger, and stress hits harder than usual.

Stress also works the other way. Research has found that women who feel more stressed earlier in their cycle tend to have more premenstrual symptoms later in that same cycle. Lowering the pressure where you can, before the harder days arrive, is therefore part of the approach.

The good news is that what you do with these feelings makes a difference. Studies show that learning to recognise premenstrual thoughts and respond to them differently, an approach taken from cognitive behavioural therapy, can ease anxiety and low mood. Interestingly, simply knowing more about PMS doesn't seem to be enough on its own. **It's the practical skills, such as planning ahead and stepping back from your thoughts, that help.**

> *The thoughts that come up in these days can feel very true in the moment, and look quite different a week later.*

YOUR MOOD

Try this *cycle*

TO-DOS

- [ ] Mark the days your symptoms usually start in your calendar, for at least the next two cycles.
- [ ] Move demanding conversations, deadlines or busy social plans away from those days where you can.
- [ ] When a thought feels heavy, name it for what it is: your premenstrual brain talking. Write it down, and look at it again after your period.
- [ ] Tell one person close to you which days are usually harder for you, and what helps you then.
- [ ] Keep moving throughout your cycle. It can ease low mood and tension too (more under "Your energy").

REFLECT

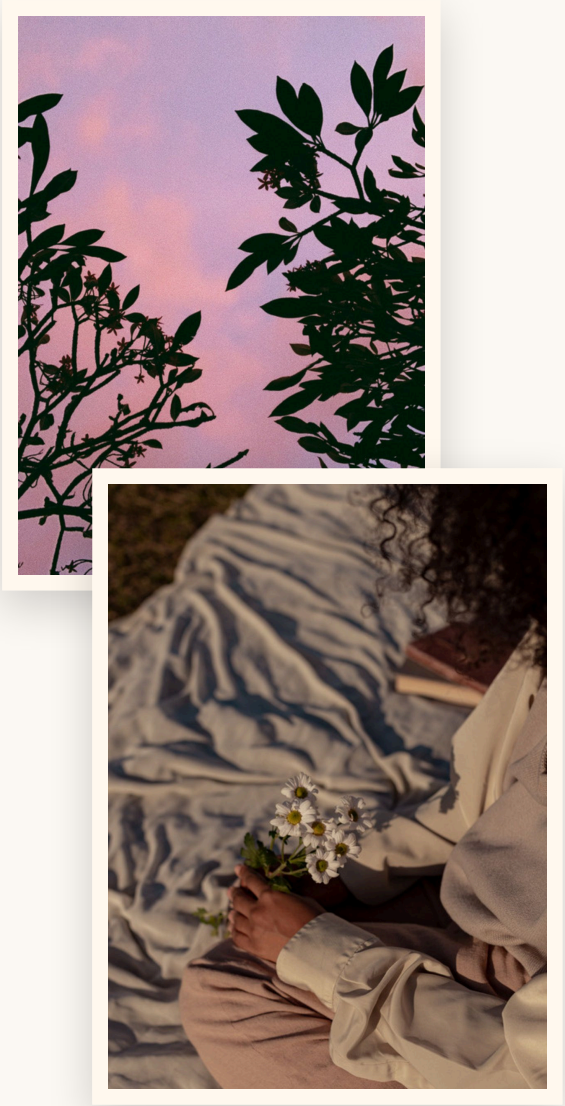
Which thoughts come back every cycle? Which of them still feel true after your period?

What would you like the people around you to know about these days?

What helps you most when you feel this way, even a little?

WHAT YOU CAN DO

Your *sleep*



Your sleep is guided by an internal clock in your brain that runs on a roughly 24-hour rhythm: your circadian rhythm. It decides when you feel alert and when you feel sleepy, and **it is set mainly by light.**

Daylight in the morning tells your clock that the day has started. About fourteen to sixteen hours later, your brain starts releasing melatonin, the hormone that makes you sleepy. Your body temperature also drops in the evening, which is one of the signals your body uses to fall asleep.

After ovulation, progesterone raises your body temperature slightly. **This means the evening drop is smaller**, which can make it harder to fall asleep and make your sleep lighter.

+0.3 to 0.7°

After ovulation, your body temperature is around 0.3 to 0.7 °C higher than in the first half of your cycle.

Some studies also suggest that the rhythm of melatonin can shift in the days before a period, especially in people with stronger symptoms.

You can't change your hormones, but **you can give your internal clock clear signals.** Morning daylight, regular sleep times, a cool bedroom and less bright light from screens in the evening all help your body recognise when it's time to sleep.

YOUR SLEEP

Try this *cycle*

TO-DOS

- [ ] Keep your bedroom cool, and use a lighter duvet if you tend to wake up warm.
- [ ] Go to bed and get up at around the same time every day, also at weekends.
- [ ] Get outside in daylight first thing in the morning, even for ten minutes.
- [ ] Have your last coffee or other caffeine before early afternoon, and skip alcohol in the evening.
- [ ] Give yourself an hour without screens before bed.

REFLECT

How is your sleep in the week before your period, compared to the rest of your cycle?

What usually keeps you awake, or wakes you up, in these days?

Which part of your evening could you change to help your sleep in the week before your period?

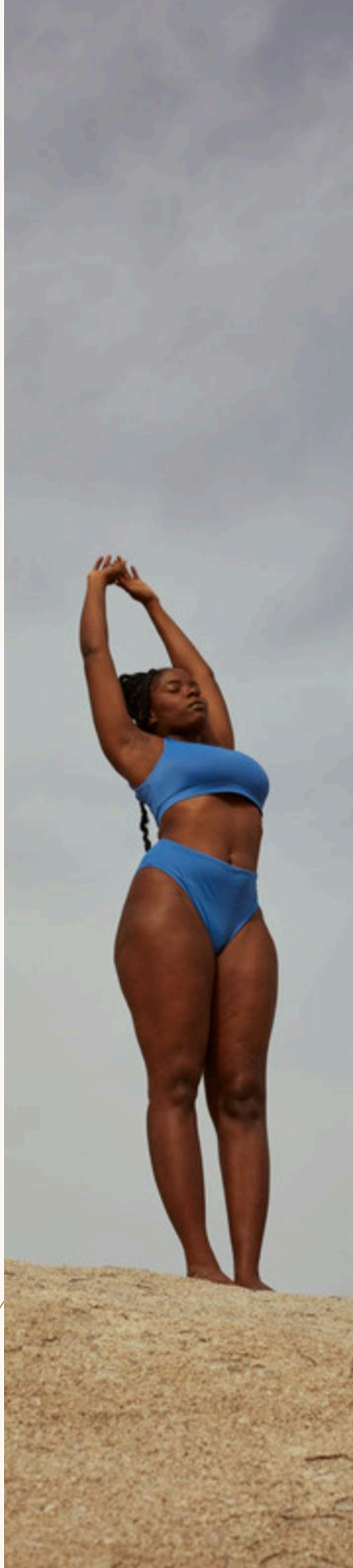
WHAT YOU CAN DO

Your *energy*

Feeling tired before your period is common, and it usually has more than one cause. Your sleep can be lighter in these days, the drop in hormones can lower your mood and motivation, and your body is working slightly harder than in the first half of your cycle. Together, that can leave you feeling flat, slow or foggy.

It may sound strange to move more when you feel tired, but this is where the research is most consistent. Studies that brought together many trials show that **regular exercise reduces premenstrual symptoms overall**, including tiredness, low mood and physical discomfort. Most of these trials asked women to move about three times a week, with activities such as brisk walking, cycling, aerobics or yoga, and the benefits showed up after about two months.

There are several reasons why movement helps. It improves the quality of your sleep, it lifts your mood, and over time it makes everyday activities feel less tiring because your body gets fitter. That's also why the timing matters: **the effect comes from moving regularly across your whole cycle**, not from pushing through a hard workout on a day you already feel drained. On those days, a lighter version still counts.



YOUR ENERGY

Try this *cycle*

TO-DOS

- [ ] Move three times a week for 30 to 60 minutes, across your whole cycle. Brisk walking, cycling, swimming and yoga all count.
- [ ] On low-energy days, choose a lighter version instead of skipping it.
- [ ] Plan your most demanding tasks on the days you usually feel strongest, and keep your harder days a little lighter.

REFLECT

Which tasks drain you most before your period, and could any of them move to another week?

On which days of your cycle do you usually feel strongest?

What kind of movement do you actually enjoy, and how could you fit it into your week?

Supplements that *may help*

The to-dos on the previous pages are the foundation. Some supplements may add to them. Food comes first where it can, and supplements work best as a support, not a replacement.

Studied in PMS

Calcium

Getting enough calcium has been linked to fewer premenstrual symptoms, including physical symptoms, cravings and mood. Food is the easiest way to get it: see "Your body" and the calcium appendix.

Vitamin D

Vitamin D may ease premenstrual symptoms, especially if your levels are low. That is more likely in autumn and winter, or if you spend little time outside. Always check with your doctor before you start taking vitamin D. A simple blood test shows whether your levels are low, and your doctor can advise you on the right amount for you.

Saffron

Saffron has been studied for premenstrual mood symptoms, with promising results. The studies mostly used about 30 mg a day, usually in a capsule. That is around fifteen saffron threads, a small pinch. You can steep them in hot water or tea for about ten minutes before drinking, or add them to rice, soup or a curry. Stick to small amounts like these, because large amounts of saffron are not safe.

> *A personal note: my partner is Afghan, and in his family saffron is part of everyday life. His mother always says: "There's no need for us to drink alcohol, we have our saffron." When we drink saffron tea together, we always end up laughing, and I feel lighter afterwards, and it fits with what researchers think: saffron may work partly through serotonin, one of the messengers that helps keep your mood steady and happy :)*

SUPPLEMENTS THAT MAY HELP

Stress *and mood*

These have been studied for stress, anxiety or low mood in general:

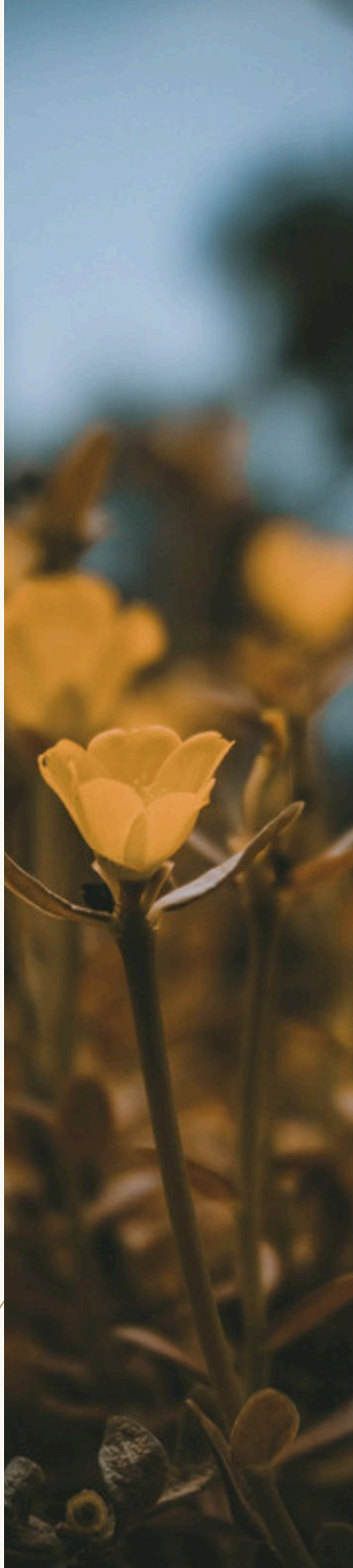
Magnesium

Magnesium may help with anxiety and sleep, especially if you don't get much of it from food. Good food sources are nuts, seeds, legumes, whole grains and dark green vegetables. You'll find a list with examples in the appendix.

Omega-3 fats

These fats are part of the walls of your brain cells and help your body calm inflammation. Research suggests they can ease low mood, and they may also reduce period pain. Eating oily fish such as salmon, mackerel or sardines once or twice a week is a good start. A fish or algae oil supplement is an option if you don't eat fish.

If you take medication, are pregnant or trying to get pregnant, check with your doctor or pharmacist before starting a supplement.



THE CYCLICAL BODY
HORMONAL HEALTH SUPPORT

PART 4

Your plan

Two to-dos, two cycles, and a simple way to see what changes.

YOUR PLAN

My plan *for this cycle*

Look back at the to-dos on the previous pages, and choose two that feel doable for this cycle.

The two to-dos I'll start with are:

1.

2.

What I want to notice this cycle is:

What might get in the way, and how I'll handle that:

YOUR PLAN

Track *two cycles*

Your memory isn't always reliable when it comes to symptoms. Looking back, it's easy to think "it's always bad" or "it wasn't that bad". A simple daily note shows you what really happens: on which days your symptoms start, how strong they are, when they ease, and whether the to-dos make a difference.

Each evening, take one minute to look back on your day. For each of the five areas from the checklist, ask yourself how much you noticed symptoms in this area today, and write down a number from 0 to 3. If you notice more than one symptom in an area, score the one that bothered you most.

- **Body:** breast tenderness or swelling, bloating, headaches, muscle or joint aches
- **Mood:** irritability or anger, low mood, anxiety or tension, mood swings, feeling overwhelmed
- **Appetite:** cravings, eating more than usual
- **Sleep:** sleeping badly, or needing much more sleep
- **Energy:** tiredness, trouble concentrating, less interest in things you usually enjoy

0
I didn't notice it.

1
I noticed it, but it didn't really affect my day.

2
It affected my day.

3
It made my day hard.

Start on the first day of your period: that is day 1. Put a dot in the "Period" column on every day you bleed. In the last two columns, tick whether you did one of your to-dos, and add a word or two if you like. When your next period starts, that's day 1 of your second cycle, and you start again on a new page.

EXAMPLE

Day	Period	Body	Mood	Appetite	Sleep	Energy	To-do done	Notes
1	•	2	1	0	1	2		Cramps
2	•	1	0	0	0	1	✓	Short walk
24		1	2	2	1	1	✓	Planned a quiet evening
26		2	3	2	2	2		Argument at work

YOUR PLAN

Cycle *1*

Day	Period	Body	Mood	Appetite	Sleep	Energy	To-do done	Notes
1								
2								
3								
4								
5								
6								
7								
8								
9								
10								
11								
12								
13								
14								
15								
16								
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30								
31								
32								
33								
34								
35								

YOUR PLAN

Cycle *2*

Day	Period	Body	Mood	Appetite	Sleep	Energy	To-do done	Notes
1								
2								
3								
4								
5								
6								
7								
8								
9								
10								
11								
12								
13								
14								
15								
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34								
35								

YOUR PLAN

What to *look for*

After two cycles, use a highlighter to mark every 2 and 3. Then look at these questions:

- ◯ Do the higher scores come back in roughly the same days before your period?
- ◯ Do they ease within a few days after your period starts?
- ◯ Are the scores in your second cycle lower than in your first, especially in the areas you worked on?
- ◯ Are there days where a to-do and a lower score go together?

After two cycles, look back: what has changed? Which to-dos made a difference, and which would you like to try next?

This workbook is for information and self-reflection. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace medical advice. If you're worried about your symptoms, contact your doctor.

SUPPORT THAT FITS YOU

What 1:1 coaching *looks like*

This workbook shows you what happens in the days before a period and what you can try. In 1:1 coaching we look at what happens in *your* body, and make a plan that fits you.

It's for you if you feel confused by your cycle, energy or symptoms, overwhelmed by conflicting advice, or tired of figuring it out alone, and you want clear, physiology-informed guidance instead of generic wellness tips.

Observe

We map what happens in your body: your symptoms, mood and energy across your cycle, whether you ovulate, and your nutrition, stress and daily rhythm.

Support

We work on the foundations of your hormonal health: nutrition, key nutrients, blood sugar, sleep and stress.

Embody

You learn to recognise your patterns before they escalate, and to trust your body through your own experience instead of rules.

What you get in 4 months

5 hours of 1:1 time

A 30-minute intake call, a 90-minute deep-dive session and six 30-minute follow-up sessions.

Support in between

Ongoing chat support for the whole 4 months, so you're never stuck waiting for the next session.

The full picture of your body

An in-depth review of your health history, a food journal analysis and nutritional assessment, your cycle charts and your available blood work.

A plan that fits you

Personalised lifestyle recommendations and optional supplement guidance. Optional: a DUTCH test with analysis.

€947 for the full 4-month program, with a payment plan available.



SUPPORT THAT FITS YOU

Want guidance *tailored to you?*

I've helped many women move from monthly PMS to an easy premenstrual week, and from feeling at war with their cycle to working with their hormonal rhythm instead of fighting it.

Tracked two cycles and still struggling? That's exactly when a call is useful. In a free discovery call we look at what may be contributing to your symptoms, and whether 1:1 coaching is the right fit for you.

Schedule a free discovery call

The discovery call is free and always available. 1:1 coaching has only 4 spots open per month.

> *"She made me feel safe and supported all the time and gave me profound, clear and helpful tools to integrate in my daily life. There were always options and I never felt that I failed with her."*
>
> MIKA MERAKI, 1:1 COACHING

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THE CYCLICAL BODY
HORMONAL HEALTH SUPPORT

APPENDIX

Food *that helps*

Getting enough calcium, how to build a plate, and getting enough magnesium.

APPENDIX

Getting enough *calcium*

Most women need around 1,000 mg of calcium a day. In the largest study on calcium and PMS, women took 1,200 mg a day as a supplement for three months. The list below shows roughly how much calcium you get from common foods. Amounts vary by brand and product, so check the label where you can.

Food	Portion	Calcium (approx.)
Milk	1 glass (250 ml)	300 mg
Fortified soy or oat drink	1 glass (250 ml)	300 mg
Cheese, such as Gouda	2 slices (40 g)	300 mg
Plain yoghurt	1 bowl (150 g)	180 mg
Tinned sardines, with bones	1 small tin (90 g)	350 mg
Tofu made with calcium	100 g	200 to 350 mg
Cooked kale	1 portion (100 g)	100 to 150 mg
White beans, cooked	1 portion (100 g)	70 mg
Almonds	1 handful (30 g)	75 mg
Tahini	1 tablespoon (15 g)	20 to 90 mg (more in whole-seed tahini)

For example: a glass of fortified soy drink with breakfast, two slices of cheese at lunch and a bowl of yoghurt in the evening already gives you close to 800 mg.

- ◯ Spread calcium over the day. Your body absorbs it better in smaller amounts than in one large portion.
- ◯ If you drink plant milk, choose one with added calcium. Not all plant drinks have it, so check the label, and shake the carton, because the calcium can settle at the bottom.
- ◯ Look for tofu with calcium on the ingredient list. It's often listed as calcium sulphate.
- ◯ Spinach contains calcium, but your body absorbs very little of it. Kale, broccoli and pak choi are better green sources.
- ◯ Vitamin D helps your body absorb calcium, so getting outside in daylight also helps. See "Supplements that may help" for more about vitamin D.

How to build *a plate*

A filling meal keeps you going for longer and makes it less likely that hunger turns into strong cravings later in the day. You don't need to weigh or count anything. Use your plate as a guide.

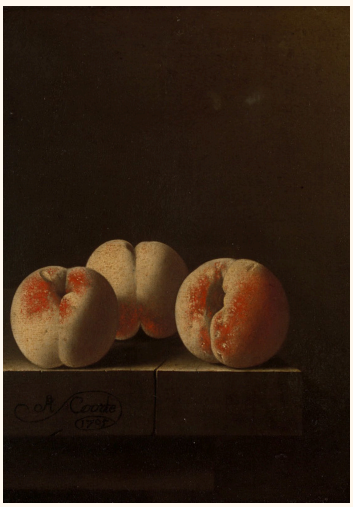
Part of your plate	What to put there	Why it helps
Half	Non-starchy vegetables, such as leafy greens, broccoli, courgette, peppers or tomatoes	Fibre and volume, so you feel full for longer
A quarter	Protein, such as eggs, fish, chicken, tofu, tempeh, beans, lentils, yoghurt or cheese	Keeps you satisfied and steadies your energy
A quarter	Wholegrain or starchy foods, such as wholegrain bread, oats, brown rice, potatoes or wholewheat pasta	Slow-release energy
A little	Healthy fat, such as olive oil, nuts, seeds or avocado	Helps your body absorb fat-soluble vitamins, such as vitamins A, D, E and K, and helps you feel full

In the days before your period, it's fine to make your portions a little bigger or to add a snack. Your body uses slightly more energy then.

Snacks that fill you up

A good snack combines some protein or fat with fibre, so it keeps you going for longer.

- ◯ An apple or pear with a tablespoon of peanut butter
- ◯ Plain yoghurt with nuts or seeds and some fruit
- ◯ Wholegrain crackers or rice cakes with cheese
- ◯ Carrot, cucumber or pepper sticks with hummus
- ◯ A handful of nuts with a few dried apricots
- ◯ A boiled egg with a few cherry tomatoes
- ◯ A slice of wholegrain bread with avocado
- ◯ A few squares of dark chocolate with a handful of almonds
- ◯ Cottage cheese or skyr with berries
- ◯ Roasted chickpeas



APPENDIX

Getting enough *magnesium*

Most women need around 300 mg of magnesium a day. Many people get less than that, often because they eat few whole grains, nuts or seeds. The list below shows roughly how much magnesium you get from common foods. Amounts vary by product, so check the label where you can.

Food	Portion	Magnesium (approx.)
Pumpkin seeds	2 tablespoons (20 g)	100 mg
Almonds	1 handful (30 g)	80 mg
Cashews	1 handful (30 g)	80 mg
Cooked spinach	1 portion (100 g)	80 mg
Cooked black beans	1 portion (100 g)	70 mg
Dark chocolate, 70% or more	3 squares (30 g)	65 mg
Brown rice, cooked	1 portion (150 g)	65 mg
Oats	1 bowl of porridge (40 g)	55 mg
Wholegrain bread	2 slices (70 g)	55 mg
Banana	1 medium	30 mg

For example: a bowl of porridge with two tablespoons of pumpkin seeds at breakfast, two slices of wholegrain bread at lunch and a portion of spinach with dinner already gives you close to 300 mg.

- ◯ Choose wholegrain over white bread, rice and pasta. Most of the magnesium sits in the outer layer of the grain, which is removed in white versions.
- ◯ Keep a jar of nuts or seeds within reach, and sprinkle them over yoghurt, porridge or salad.
- ◯ Add a handful of beans or lentils to soups, stews and salads.
- ◯ A few squares of dark chocolate count too, in moderation ;)
- ◯ If you're thinking about a magnesium supplement, choose a good-quality one. Some studies suggest that forms such as magnesium citrate or magnesium bisglycinate are absorbed better by your body than magnesium oxide, which is often used in cheaper products. Stick to the dose on the label and don't take more than 250 mg a day from supplements, because higher doses can cause loose stools. If you take medication, check with your doctor or pharmacist first, as magnesium can interact with some medicines.